producer Vaishal Shah of Jannock Films—known for his hit movie *Chhello Divas* (2015), another landmark film that infused energy in the fledgling industry—highlights that Gujarati cinema still faces an uphill battle when competing with Bollywood films for eyeballs. "Every year, around 100 [Gujarati] films are made, of which 70 are released in cinemas. Less than 10 survive beyond three weeks because our films compete directly with Hindi ones. On the Diwali weekend, a good film like *Hahacar* struggled against multi-starrer Hindi films like *Singham Again* and *Bhool Bhulaiyaa 3*...but picked up after two weeks," he says. A situational suspense comedy, *Hahacar* went on to make about Rs 7 crore at the box office.



"AUDIENCES WANT REGIONAL FLAVOUR, STORIES OF THE SOIL TOLD IN THEIR LANGUAGE, NOT BOLLYWOOD RIP-OFFS"

SAUMYA JOSHI, *Playwright-lyricist*

"THE GUJARATI FILM INDUSTRY IS STILL FINDING ITS VOICE, BUT THE RANGE OF STORIES BEING TOLD NOW IS ENCOURAGING"



RAAM MORI, *Gujarati screenwriter*

The Elusive Hits

Distributor Murli Chhatwani explains that for a Gujarati film to be considered a hit, it must earn 25–30 per cent over its cost. "If it earns this from theatres, it is considered a superhit," he says. However, this level of success remains elusive for most Gujarati films. The average box-office return of a hit is in the range of Rs 6-8 crore while a superhit film could rake in Rs 20-25 crore—a pittance of what a Hindi or a southern film earns. The highest-grossing Gujarati film to date is *Chaal Jeevi Laiye* (2019), a comedy drama, which earned Rs 52 crore. It continues to be a distant benchmark for most filmmakers.

According to Chhatwani, who distributes regional films across North India, Gujarati and Marathi audiences often prefer Hindi cinema over regional films, unlike Punjabi or South Indian audiences who prioritise their local industries. He also explains how Gujarati films struggle abroad, where NRI viewers tend to watch pirated versions rather than supporting filmmakers through legal streaming platforms like JoJo, ShemarooMe and MX Player. Playwright-lyricist Saumya Joshi feels the Gujarati industry can break linguistic barriers only through powerful storytelling—"stories of the soil" like *Hellaro* and *Kutch Express*, not "Bollywood rip-offs". Film publicist Chetan Chauhan concurs and adds that filmmakers need to substantially boost their marketing budgets, covering a wider network of semi-urban and rural areas. "Both budget and vision are a constraint," he says. Notably, even as Bollywood's ace music composers like Sachin-Jigar regularly make time to work for Gujarati films, the cash-rich Bollywood studios are mostly staying away.

Adding to the woes of filmmakers are structural challenges. Abhishek Jain, who directed *Kevi Rite Jaish*, highlights the absence of a formal film producers' guild, unorganised finance and limited recovery avenues, making investing in Gujarati cinema risky. "There's no common trade analysis window, leading to arbitrary claims and disputes. We also require subsidised rates for marketing and facilities like recording studios," he adds. Additionally, the lack of film schools training actors, writers and technical crew exacerbates the constraints on available talent.

The urban-rural divide further complicates the growth of Gujarati cinema. The 'rural Gujarati film industry' is a parallel one, with a different set of actors, production houses et al. So, it's unlikely to find 'superstar' Vikram Thakor, who draws rural audiences in hordes, work in a so-called 'urban' film. Actor Hiten Kumar, a veteran of Gujarati cinema, points out that 25-30 such rural films are being made every year. The decline of single-screen, or junta, theatres—where tickets were sold for just Rs 50—has alienated rural viewers, he feels; earlier, families could enjoy an evening at the movies for a fraction of today's costs. That's the reason film producers are pushing the state government to make multiplexes do away with the fixed service fee of Rs 25 on the sale of each ticket, a turn-off for the audiences. This is over and above the 55 per cent of the ticket cost that they pocket. "Of the balance, 10 per cent goes to the distributor. We are left with a meagre 35 per cent," says Vaishal Shah.

On its part, the government is stepping up to support the industry. Subsidies introduced in 2016 have provided some relief. Ranging from Rs 5 lakh to Rs 75 lakh, they allow producers to experiment. So, the Naseeruddin Shah-starring children's film *Dhh* (2017) may not have worked at the box office but had a good run in festivals and recovered part of its cost through subsidies post release. "Audiences will appreciate Gujarati films only if they are made. Not all will succeed, but that's part of the learning process," says Chauhan. As writers, producers and directors hone their craft, the Gujarati film industry inches closer to realising its full potential—one film at a time. ■